Introduction

The National School, Nallur, organised a field trip to a nearby village called Anaikkadu. The students were so happy to see a village with ponds, streams, green fields and coconut trees. With the help of their teacher students were allowed to go around. One of them saw two birds building a nest. Where do the birds build nests and why?

Children saw a number of butterflies fluttering near the flowers. The air was so fresh, so calm, so quiet and so relaxing. They came across a pond in the distance. It had some water. Floating on the water were dark green lotus leaves. A green frog was leaping from one lotus leaf to another making a croaking sound. A girl spotted a rabbit with a short tail.

Can you make a list of the animals seen by the children? Were they all similar? In what way they were similar?

5.1 Biodiversity

In the living world, a lot of diversity is seen both in animals and plants. Every plant and animal is unique. It is called biodiversity. Biodiversity may be defined as the variety and variability among living organisms and the habitats in which they live.

Biodiversity includes a variety of ecosystems such as those that occur in deserts, forests, mountains, lakes, rivers and agricultural fields. In each ecosystem, living creatures, including humans, form a community interacting with one another and with other animals, plants, air, water and soil around them. The living things form biotic community and non-living things form abiotic community.

Habitat

Fishes and crabs live only in water while many animals like elephants, tigers and camels live on land. The geographical features and environmental conditions on earth differ from one place to another. Though camel can live anywhere it is able to live in deserts more comfortably. Polar bear and penguins dwell in cold regions. Living in such harsh conditions requires special features in these animals. They help these organisms to live, breed and excel well in that particular place. Living or dwelling place of an organism is known as **habitat.**

Activity 1

Look at the picture given below and prepare a chart for the following interpretation.

- How does the climate differ in these habitats?
- Name some animals that exist in these habitats.
- Can an animal survive if it is shifted from one habitat to another contrasting habitat?



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